

BAYLOR ACADEMY FOR TEACHING AND LEARNING

Cultivating Attention in a Distracted Era

Strategies for Engaging Today's Learners

Toby Brooks, Director, ATL

Megan Alstot, Postdoctoral Research Associate, ATL

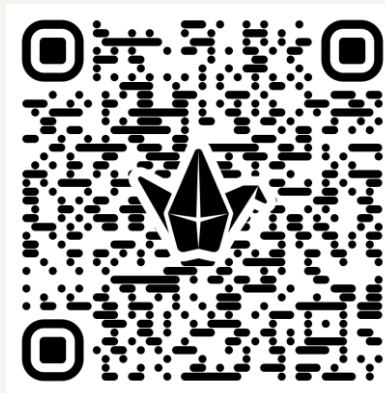
OPENING REFLECTION

What are you seeing in your classrooms this semester?

Take 2 minutes.

Drop a sticky note on the Padlet wall.
Anonymous. One sentence is plenty.

What's working, what isn't, what's new.



Scan to add

Purpose, Task, Criteria for Success

PURPOSE

Examine ways we can help our students (and ourselves) cultivate attention as the antidote to distraction.

TASK

Reflect on a typical class session. Identify where attention is renewed — and where it isn't.

CRITERIA FOR SUCCESS

Leave with at least one specific, low-lift strategy you will test before our next session.

MEET YOUR STUDENT

Maya, age 19

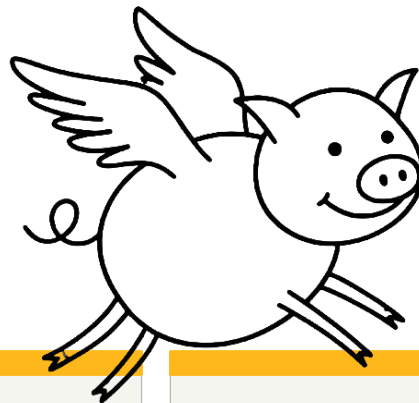
- Born 2007; in 7th grade when COVID closed school
- First generation to attend college with generative AI freely available
- Higher baseline anxiety; ~1 in 6 has a formal ADHD diagnosis
- Carries real debt anxiety (66% cite as top concern)
- Prefers face-to-face communication, but anxious about office hours
- Socially conscious, entrepreneurial — paying attention to whether you are



Created by Gemini

Three myths about attention

Releasing frames that misallocate our energy.



MYTH

Students today have shorter attention spans.

TRUTH

Attention has always needed cultivation. There is no evidence of a fixed or shrinking span.

MYTH

Technology causes distraction.

TRUTH

Technology is a vector, not a cause. The mind wandered before phones existed.

MYTH

Distraction is a character flaw.

TRUTH

Distraction is how brains work. The work is design, not enforcement.

Distraction is not new. Attention has always been an achievement.

Three Principles of Attentiveness

1

Attention is
an achievement

2

Attention
remains achievable

3

If we want it,
we must cultivate
it deliberately

Be explicit with the WHY

TiLT — Transparency in Learning and Teaching.

THE PRACTICE

Make purpose, task, and criteria visible to students.

Why this assignment?

What will you do?

What does success look like?

Grounded in extensive literature. Mention and move on.

WATCH (10 MIN)

Using AI to TiLT Your Rubrics

10:10:10 AI Microlearning #10



On the resource page →

Six Attention-Building Practices

Community

shared values, belonging

Curiosity

questions, wonder

Structured

modular, renewing

Signature Activities

novel, attention-renewing

Grading

design shapes attention

Mindful

presence, compassion

Today: practices 1–5. Mindful — on the resource page.



Comm



Curi



Struc



Sig



Grad



Mind

Community

Shared values. Authentic presence. Strengths surfaced.



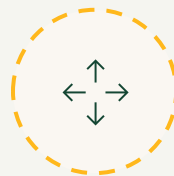
AFFIRM

Values. Strengths.
Surface what each
student brings.



KNOW

Names. Name tents.
Effort over
perfection.



MOVE

Rearrange the room.
Teach from
everywhere.

Curiosity

Invite curiosity using questions.



REWRITE

Course description as invitation, not summary.



WONDER

Day-one mystery. Surface the excitement of your discipline.



ASK

Daily questions. Predict before reveal.



INVITE

Help students learn to ask their own questions.

AI-assist • REWRITE: intros, analogies, images

Copilot rewrites a course description

Drop in a screenshot from your Copilot session here

THE PROMPT

I teach MGT 3320 — Distribution Management. Here is my current course description:

This course focuses on the distribution process from point of manufacturer to the point of use. Major topics include: evolution and trends, structure of durable and nondurable goods industries, types of intermediaries...

Help me rewrite this to spark curiosity instead of summarizing content. Pose 2–3 genuine questions and invite students in.

Ask me three clarifying questions and STOP.

Then offer four rewrites <120 words, each from a different angle:

- **Disciplinary mystery**
- **Hidden system**
- **Question + story**
- **Movie trailer**

3. Question + Metaphorical Story

What did it take to put that cold Coke in your hand? Not just the formula—but the truck routes, warehouses,



1. Disciplinary Mystery

Why do intermediaries keep surviving the technologies that claim they'll disappear? If the internet, Amazon, and now AI promise direct connection, why do middlemen keep returning—often stronger than before?

In this course, you'll take that question seriously. You'll trace how goods move, test where value is actually created, and examine why distribution structures persist. This requires systems thinking and analytical reasoning—following flows, incentives, and tradeoffs. By the end, you won't just recognize distribution—you'll question what it does, who it serves, and why it refuses to go away.

2. Hidden System

Look around you: your phone, your coffee, your chair. Each arrived through a system you don't see. Why is that system so easy to ignore—and so costly to build?

This course is about making that invisible structure visible. You'll map how products move, identify where value is added, and analyze what happens when parts fail or disappear. You'll practice systems thinking and critical analysis, learning to see distribution not as background, but as the work itself. By week 3, you may start asking: is this system designed, or just inherited?

Copilot generates ideas for attention openers

Second screenshot placeholder — your second example.

THE PROMPT

Suggest five different attention prompts I could use in the first two minutes of class on Distribution Management.

Include:

- a question
- a low-stakes freewrite
- a prediction prompt
- an image-based observation
- a retrieval cue from prior content

Each prompt under 30 words — just the prompt, not the full activity.



Copilot

- **Question:**
"What's one factor that most influences a company's choice of distribution channels?"
- **Low-stakes freewrite:**
"In 60 seconds, jot down everything that comes to mind when you hear 'distribution management.' No wrong answers."
- **Prediction prompt:**
"Predict: how will same-day delivery expectations reshape distribution networks over the next five years?"
- **Image-based observation prompt:**
"Look at this supply chain image—what patterns or bottlenecks do you notice first?"
- **Retrieval cue:**
"From last class: what are the three main functions of intermediaries in distribution?"

Structured

Make your class session modular. Attend → Process → Retrieve.

SAMPLE 80-MIN STRUCTURE

A	10 min	Opening activity
P	15 min	Lecture
P	15 min	Group activity (formative)
P	10 min	Share-out + input
P	15 min	Lecture
R	5 min	Revisit opening
R	10 min	Exit ticket (low-stakes)

A Attend **P** Process **R** Retrieve

Lang (2020). Lang (2021), Small Teaching 2nd Ed.

CHUNK

10–15 min segments

VISIBLE

Share the schedule

RENEW

Design renewal in

SHOW

Less text. More images.

AI-assist · SHOW: images, diagrams, visual analogies



Comm



Curi



Struc



Sig



Grad



Mind

Signature Activity: See / Think / Wonder



SEE

What do you notice?

THINK

What's going on here?

WONDER

What questions arise?

OTHER SIGNATURE ACTIVITIES

Concept maps · group annotation · polls ·
memes · making connections

What grades can do



USED REFLEXIVELY

diminish · narrow · flatten

Grades can reduce interest, push to easiest path, lower thinking quality.



USED INTENTIONALLY

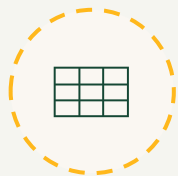
low-stakes · resubmit · oops

Same tool, designed for attention and motivation. Less redesign than ungrading.

"The opposite of cheating is learning, not integrity." — Bertram Gallant & Rettinger (2025)

The AI Assist

AI does what it does best: rapid creative variation. You bring the pedagogy.



STRUCTURE

Build 15-min
class cycles



CURIOSITY

Generate openers,
descriptions



RETRIEVAL

Design end-of-block
consolidation



ENGAGEMENT

Novel activities to
renew attention

Five prompts on the resource page. The Gift on slide 17.

[FULL PROMPTS →](#)

Pay attention.
Be astonished.
Tell about it.

— Mary Oliver, "Sometimes"



THE GIFT

Prompts · readings · video

REFERENCES

Sources

Bertram Gallant, T., & Rettinger, D. A. (2025). The opposite of cheating: Teaching for integrity in the age of AI. University of Oklahoma Press.

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McMurtrie, B. (2024, November 4). Cheating has become normal. The Chronicle of Higher Education.

Oliver, M. (2008). Sometimes. In Red bird. Beacon Press.

Winkelmes, M.-A. TiLT Higher Ed framework. (Cited in Slide 7 video resource.)

Note: Kohn quotes on grades cited via Lang (2020).